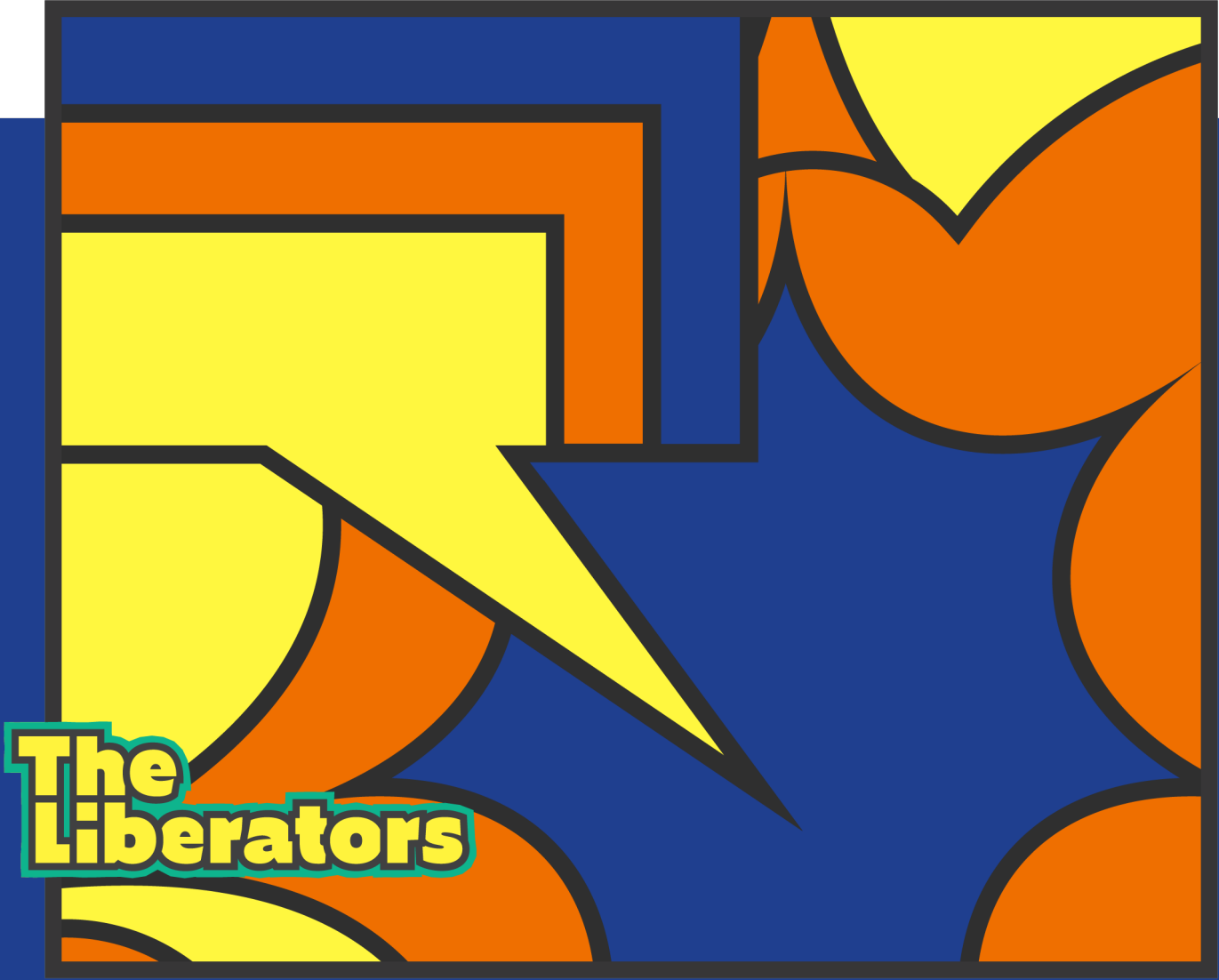


10 Powerful Experiments To Overcome Zombie Scrum

Use these experiments to create (painful) transparency, to inspect together with the Scrum team, and then to improve the situation!

An abstract graphic featuring a dark blue background with large, bold, stylized shapes in orange and yellow. The shapes are outlined in black and have a hand-drawn, geometric feel. In the bottom left corner, the text "The Liberators" is written in a bold, yellow, sans-serif font with a thick black outline and a slight shadow effect.

**The
Liberators**

In This Paper



As a Scrum Master, Agile Coach, Product Owner, or member of a Scrum team, you need all your creativity to overcome the many hard challenges that (Zombie) Scrum throws at you. Although it can be tempting to give up, we always remind people that the Scrum framework is like exercising. It can be uncomfortable and cause sore muscles, but it is worth it for a healthier lifestyle. In a similar vein, the Scrum framework exists to reduce the risk of complex work. And getting there hurts, as most organizations are still pointlessly trying to avoid risk through detailed upfront planning, infrequent releases, and command-and-control hierarchies.

In order to overcome these challenges, you need a toolbox of skills, practices, and techniques to draw from. We've found it helpful in our own practice as Scrum Masters to have a toolbox of concrete "experiments" to create (painful) transparency, to inspect together with the team, and then improve the situation. Just like real recipes, they are specific enough to achieve something useful, and they can be tweaked to fit the context.

This paper contains 10 experiments. You can find many more in our book, ["The Zombie Scrum Survival Guide"](#). For each experiment, we begin with the purpose. Then we describe the steps. We also offer some experiences based on our findings that may help you. Finally, we offer*additional resources.

Enjoy reading the paper, and most important: try the experiments with your team and organization. Let's fight Zombie Scrum, together!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



1. Diagnose Your Team Together With The Scrum Team Survey

[Zombie Scrum](#) is on the rise! Although it may look like Scrum from a distance, with all the roles, events, and artifacts you'd expect, it turns out to be anything but on closer inspection. There is no valuable Increment at the end of a Sprint, stakeholders are not involved, autonomy is very low and nobody is trying to improve anything about the situation.

This experiment is all about helping your team get clear on where they stand between Professional Scrum and Zombie Scrum. Although the results may be painful, it is better to face the truth and make your first steps towards recovery.

Below we share a short version of how to run this experiment. Check our webshop for [a detailed description](#) with many more examples on how to use it.

Improve Your Scrum Team, Continuously

Diagnose your team with our scientifically validated survey, inspect the results together, and improve with our evidence-based feedback.

[Diagnose Team \(Free\)](#)[View demo profile](#)

Metric	Teams (Green)	Stakeholders (Yellow)	Range (Pink)
Responsiveness	Low	High	Medium
Continuous Improvement	Low	High	Medium
Stakeholder Concern	Low	High	Medium
Team Autonomy	Low	None	Medium
Team Effectiveness	Low	High	Medium
Management Support	Low	None	Medium

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill	☆☆☆☆	No skill is required for filling in a survey and inspecting the results together with your team.
Impact On Survival	★★★★★	This workshop creates transparency around what is going on in your team its environment. It's a crucial first step towards improvement.



Steps

To implement this experiment, do the following:

1. Go to the [Scrum Team Survey](#) and fill out the extensive free survey for your Scrum team. After you have completed the first survey invite others from your team to join your 'sample' as instructed by the site. To protect the privacy of participants and to avoid abuse, individual scores are only shown to the participants themselves.
2. When you complete the survey, you receive a detailed report. The report is updated every time someone joins the sample. In the report, we offer you scores on the key symptoms of Zombie Scrum, as well as a more detailed breakdown. The report also gives feedback and recommendations based on that. When everyone has participated, schedule a 1-hour workshop to inspect the results together. We recommend doing this with only the Scrum team;
3. Prepare for the workshop. Print the report and hand them out, put prints on the walls or simply put up the profile on a screen;
4. Start the workshop by reiterating the purpose clearly and emphasizing what will happen with the outcomes (and what won't). Make sure to emphasize that improvement is always a gradual, incremental, and often messy process and that this workshop is a step in that process;
5. Invite everyone to silently inspect the results and note down observations. Ask: "What do you notice in the results?". Encourage people to stick to the facts, and avoid jumping to conclusions, for the first round. After a few minutes, ask people to share their observations in pairs for another couple of minutes and notice similarities and differences. If you have eight or more people, ask pairs to join another pair and take a few minutes to share observations and notice patterns. Ask the small groups to share their most important insights with the whole group, and capture them in a way that remains visible to everyone present;
6. Repeat twice more with different questions, using the pattern outlined earlier. For round 2, ask people: "So, what does this mean for our work as a team?" For round 3, ask people: "Where do we have the freedom and autonomy to improve as a team? What are small, first steps we can commit to?" Make sure to keep gathering the outcomes;
7. Put the most important actionable improvement on the Sprint Backlog for the next Sprint. Involve others as needed to keep making progress. Use the Sprint Retrospective to explore what has changed and improved.



How To Read The Report



High-Level Results

After you complete the survey you receive a high-level overview and a detailed breakdown of the results. The high-level overview shows the results for six areas: Responsiveness, Continuous Improvement, Stakeholder Concern, Team Autonomy, Management Support, and Team Effectiveness. In the example above you can see that 4 team members and 6 stakeholders have completed the survey.

Detailed Results

In addition to the high-level overview, the report also contains a detailed breakdown of the results. For example, the visualization shows how "Responsiveness" contains the subtopics "Release Automation", "Refinement", "Release Frequency", and "Stakeholder Experience: Release Frequency". These detailed results give your team the opportunity for a closer inspection and to define improvements accordingly.

During the workshop, you can first explore the high-level results per theme, and then study the detailed results for the ones that stand out the most.

Feedback On The Results

Based on the answers the team members provided in the survey, detailed feedback is offered. Use this detailed feedback as inspiration for the diagnosis workshop. Focus on the topics labeled as 'urgent' first. It's helpful to study the feedback upfront and ask everyone to share the key takeaways during the workshop.

Quick Tips

For each topic in the survey, we offer multiple Quick Tips. Quick Tips are based on the Liberating Structure [15% Solutions](#). These are actionable next steps you can take immediately. These steps are not blocked by dependencies or require permission from others. A good Quick Tips is actionable, specific, a bit courageous, and simple & easy to take simultaneously. Because the results of the survey can be overwhelming, we included the Quick Tips to help you move in the right direction. Remember: you can trigger big changes with small steps!

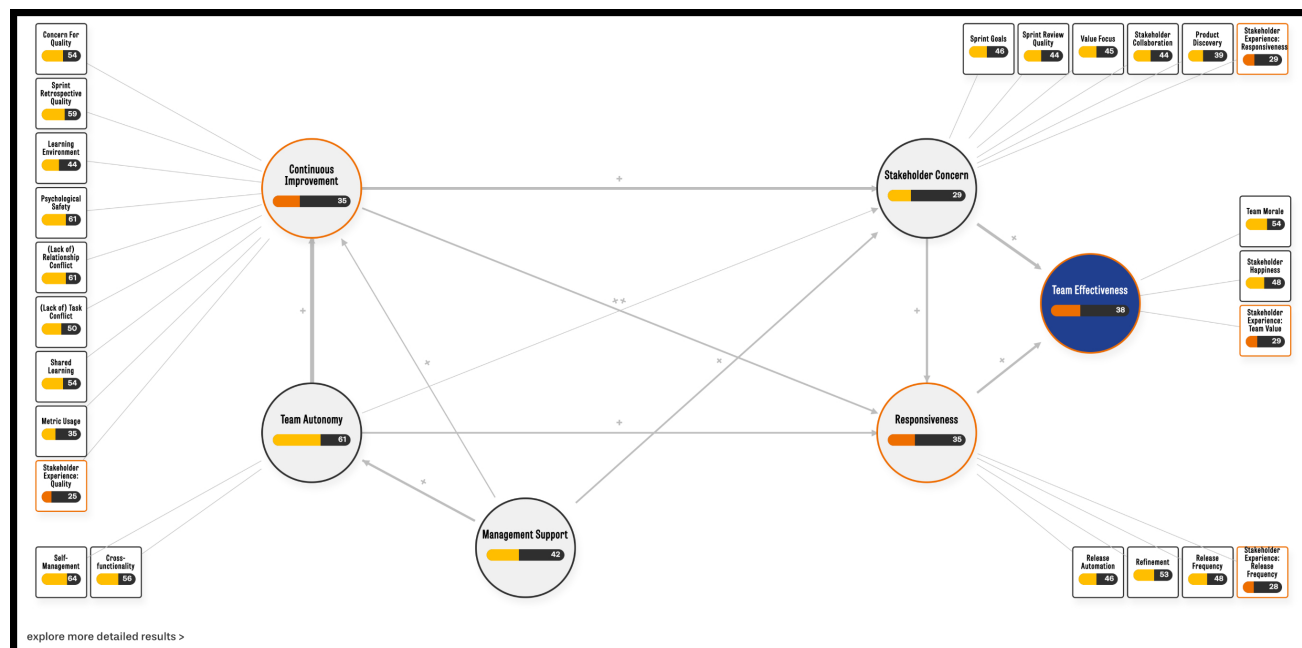
Do-It-Yourself Workshops

In addition to the Quick Tips, we also offer numerous do-it-yourself workshops. Each workshop provides a detailed facilitation guide and has a clear purpose. Based on the results of your team, we give your 3 – 5 workshops to try. These workshops help you create transparency on impediments, inspect it together with your team, and make adaptations accordingly.

How To Reduce Optimism Bias

Most people are optimists by nature. Even though we designed the survey to be as objective as possible, you may notice that people enter overly optimistic scores in some areas. For other areas, they may conclude that even mediocre results are "pretty good". When your team scores "better than average" for some topics, also take a look at the absolute score. A score of a 6 (on a scale from 1 to 10) may be "above average" for Sprint Review Quality, but is that really the best you can do? Instead of settling for "good enough", always challenge your team to see where improvement is possible.

How To Read The Model



Through our research with over 2000+ Scrum teams, we identified 5 core factors and many subfactors that determine how effective Scrum teams are at delivering valuable outcomes.

The squares in the model represent topics we measure in the survey. The topics are grouped into the 5 core factors. The arrows represent how core factors affect each other in most Scrum teams. The thicker the line, the stronger the effect.

The blue circle with "Team Effectiveness" is the outcome. The goal of this model is to improve how effective your team is. How valuable is working with Scrum for your team? Are stakeholders happy? Do people enjoy working empirically? Is the team creating value for the broader organization and for stakeholders?

This model helps you identify what to improve to become more effective. If Continuous Improvement is low, you can focus on its topics (like 'Metric Usage', 'Shared Learning', or 'Sprint Retrospective Quality'). Or you can focus on a core factor that influences it, like Management Support or Team Autonomy.

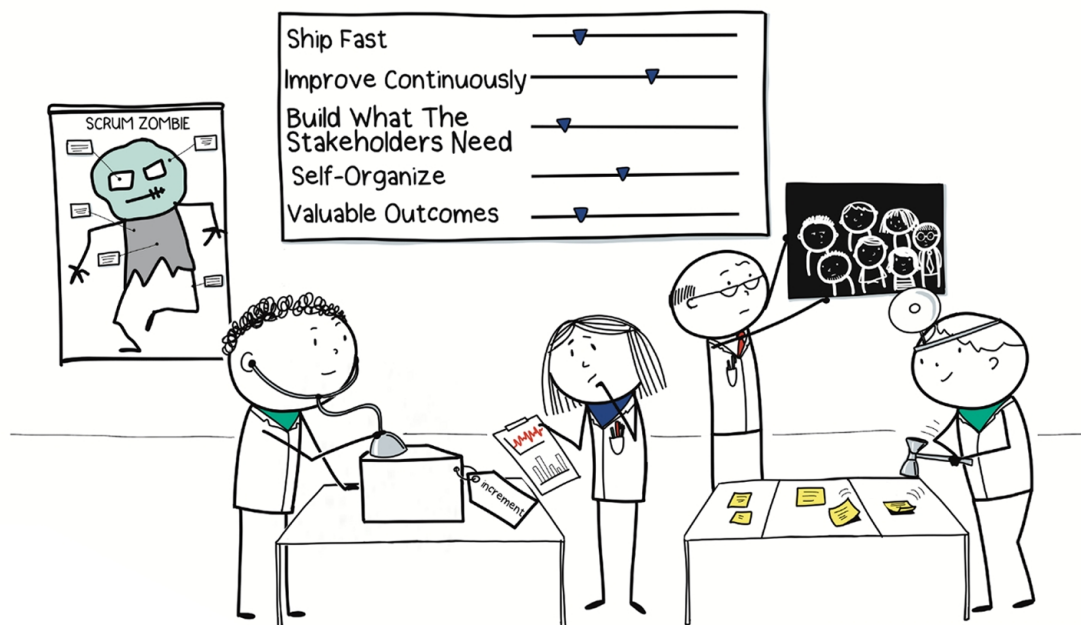
Your Scrum team will become more effective when you continuously improve on the five core factors. The best strategy is to periodically inspect the results and identify areas of improvement, together with your team and your stakeholders.

2. Increase Cross-Functionality With A Skill Matrix

Is your team experiencing bottlenecks because only one person is capable of testing work? Is a developer on your team struggling to implement something that is blocking everyone else until she is done? Do team members start work on unrelated and low-value tasks simply because they have nothing else to do? These symptoms arise when teams are not cross-functional enough, causing work to pile up for some people and creating delays for others.

The Scrum framework is built on cross-functional teams because they are better able to overcome the unpredictable challenges that arise when working on complex problems. Your team is cross-functional enough when items flow smoothly through your workflow. Cross-functionality does not mean that everyone can perform any kind of task or that you must have at least two experts for every kind of skill on your team. Often, just having another person who has a particular skill, even when they are slower and less experienced at it, already improves flow enough to prevent most problems.

This experiment offers your team practical strategies to help them improve their cross-functionality.

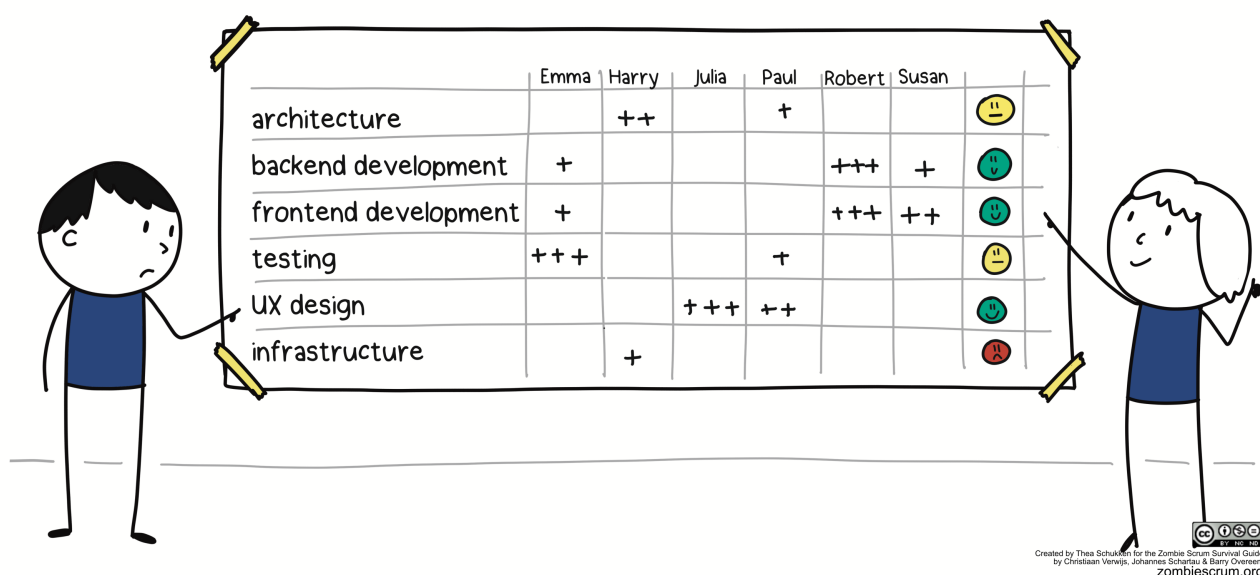


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Steps

To implement this experiment, do the following:

1. With your team, map the skills you need during a typical Sprint. Together, create a matrix on a flip chart where you plot the members of your team against the skills you identified. Invite people to decide for themselves what skills they possess and to self-rate their proficiency with it using plus signs (+, ++, and +++).
2. When you're done with the matrix, ask "What do you notice about how the skills on our team are distributed? What is immediately obvious?". Invite people to reflect on this question individually for two minutes, then for a few minutes in pairs. With the whole group, capture important patterns on a flip chart.
3. Ask "What does this mean for our work as a team? Where should we focus our improvements?" Let people reflect on this question individually, then in pairs for a few minutes, and then capture the biggest insights on the flip.
4. Ask "Where should we start improving? What first step is possible for us without needing approval from others or resources we don't have?" Let people reflect on this individually, then in pairs for a few minutes, and then capture the biggest insights on the flip chart. Use the strategies as described in the next section as inspiration when people struggle to see possibilities.
5. Keep the skill matrix in your team room and update it frequently. You can tie it to flow-based metrics such as throughput and cycle time, which should improve over time as cross-functionality increases. See the experiment "Limit Your Work in Progress" in our book to learn how to do this.



Strategies

There are many strategies to improve cross-functionality in your team.

- You can add people to your team who already have the skills that you need. Although a seemingly obvious solution, adding skilled people isn't always possible. It's also doubtful how structural this solution really is, as it can cause "Skill Whac-A-Mole," where other skills then become bottlenecks and you have to add even more specialized people. Instead of maintaining high degrees of skill specialization, it's often more effective to distribute skills.
- You can automate tasks that require scarce skills. For example, creating a backup of a database or deploying a release are critical tasks that are often performed by database specialists and release engineers. When you automate these tasks, you improve not only the speed of the activity, but also how frequently these tasks can be performed, while also removing the constraint.
- You can purposefully limit your team's work in progress, putting constraints on how much new work can be started, to encourage cross-functionality. Instead of starting a new Product Backlog item, because there isn't anything else to do, ask "How can I help others complete their current work?" or "How can others help me complete this work?" The Daily Scrum is a natural opportunity to offer and request help.
- You can encourage people to pair on tasks that only a few people can perform. When you pair experienced and inexperienced people, the less experienced people develop new skills, and both people find better ways to support each other. For example, pairing developers who typically work on the front end with developers who work on the back end makes it easier for them to support each other when bottlenecks occur.
- You can use approaches such as "Specification by Example"⁵ to allow customers, developers, and testers to work together to develop automated test cases. In a similar vein, front-end frameworks (e.g., Bootstrap, Material, or Meteor) can make it easier for designers and developers to work together with a common design language for elements.
- You can organize skill workshops where people who are skilled at a particular task demonstrate how they perform it and help others perform it.

Our Findings

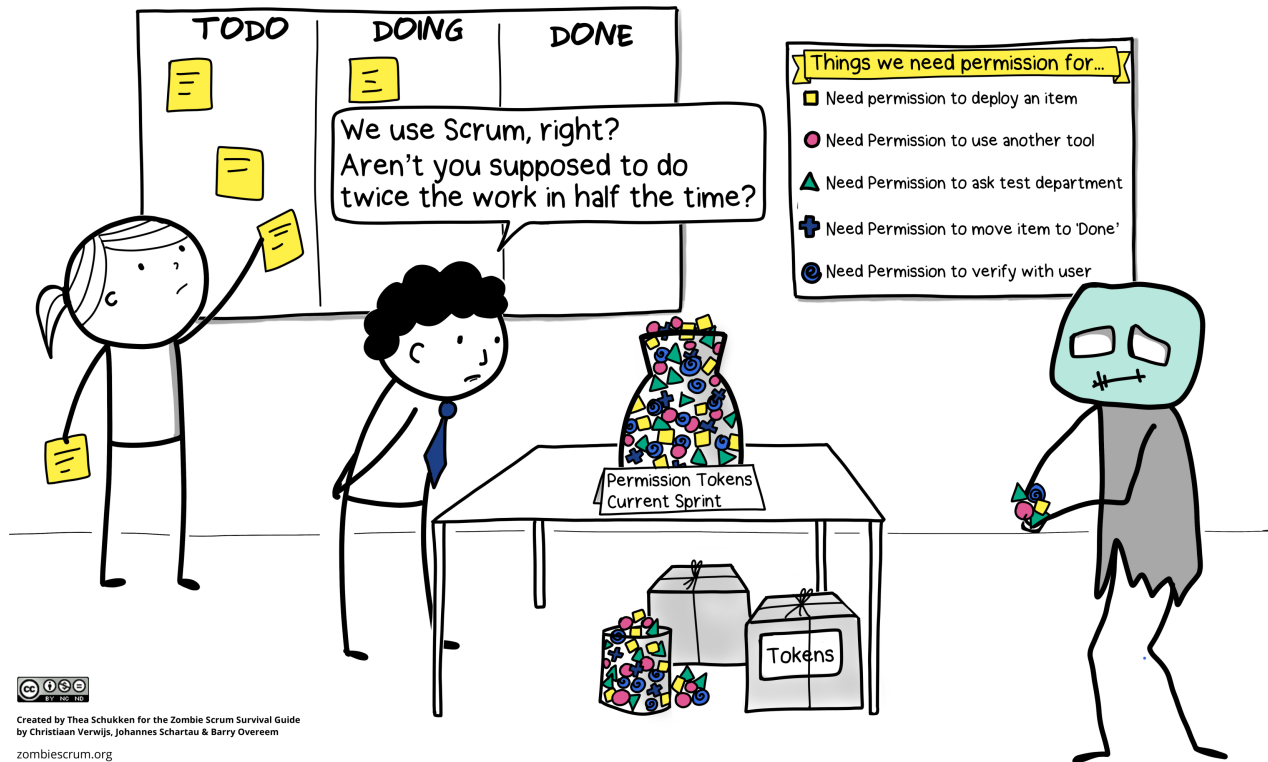
- When Scrum teams have been affected by Zombie Scrum for a long time, they may have come to believe that nothing ever changes. You may even face understandable cynicism. If this is the case, start with the smallest possible improvements to show people that change is possible and worth the time spent making it happen.
- When the skills of team members are narrowly specialized, they may struggle to see how broadening their skills will benefit the team. They may also fear losing their uniquely visible contribution to the team. Make an effort to celebrate the successes of the team to emphasize the collective outcomes over individual contributions.



3. Make The Cost Of Low Autonomy Transparent With Permission Tokens

The autonomy of teams decreases as their dependencies on external people increase. Some dependencies are explicit, such as when a Scrum Team needs someone outside the team to do something for them. Other dependencies are more implicit. Having to ask for permission or approval from someone outside the team in order to proceed is a good example.

This experiment is about making visible where and how often permission is required.



Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



This experiment requires only a jar, some tokens, and a few minutes during your Sprint Review.

Impact On Survival



Even in the most zombified environments, regaining some sense of control makes people sigh with relief.

Steps

To try this experiment, do the following:

1. Find an empty jar, or another container, and place it in the team room. Somewhere near the Sprint Backlog is the best spot.
2. Give everyone on your team a bunch of permission tokens. You can use marbles, LEGO bricks, magnets, or stickies. Use different colors for the various permission categories. For example, the permission to release something, to move an item to another column on your Scrum Board, or to change your tools or environment. We recommend a limit of five categories to keep things simple.
3. During the Sprint, put an approval token in the jar every time someone on the Scrum team has to ask permission from someone outside the team. For example, put a token in the jar when an external architect needs to approve that an item is done. Or when the Product Owner has to vet an item with an external manager. Put a token in the jar when you need permission from office management to purchase stickies. And put a token in the jar when you need a configuration to be changed by an external administrator. Aside from requests for permission, also add a token every time you need someone outside the team to perform a specific action as well.
4. During the Sprint Review, and with stakeholders present, share the number of tokens in the jar. Ask: "How does this affect our ability to quickly adapt in the moment and do what is the most valuable? Where can we simplify things?" Invite people to first consider this question for themselves and in silence, then in pairs for two minutes, and then paired with another pair for four more minutes. Capture the most salient improvements with the whole group. The Sprint Retrospective is a great opportunity for digging into potential improvements.

Our Findings

- It can be tempting to identify dozens of potential improvements and end up doing nothing at all. Instead, keep a strong focus on improving one thing first before moving on to something else. If that improvement is too big to commit to doing it in a single Sprint, make it smaller;
- Make sure the entire Scrum team participates in the workshop. Not only the Product Owner and Scrum Master. Otherwise, it will quickly become a tool to assess the Development Team. This will not only damage trust but entirely misses the point of the survey.
- Frequently conduct the survey with the entire team. Don't do it once. Make it a recurring activity. This allows the team to learn what has changed over time, and what didn't. These are probably the more challenging things to change and might need a different approach.
- Ask other teams to do the survey as well. When the organization consists of multiple Scrum teams, invite them to fill in the survey as well. This allows you to discover patterns or things that are completely different. What is it that the teams have in common? What seems to be a challenge in the organization? So what should all the teams try to improve?

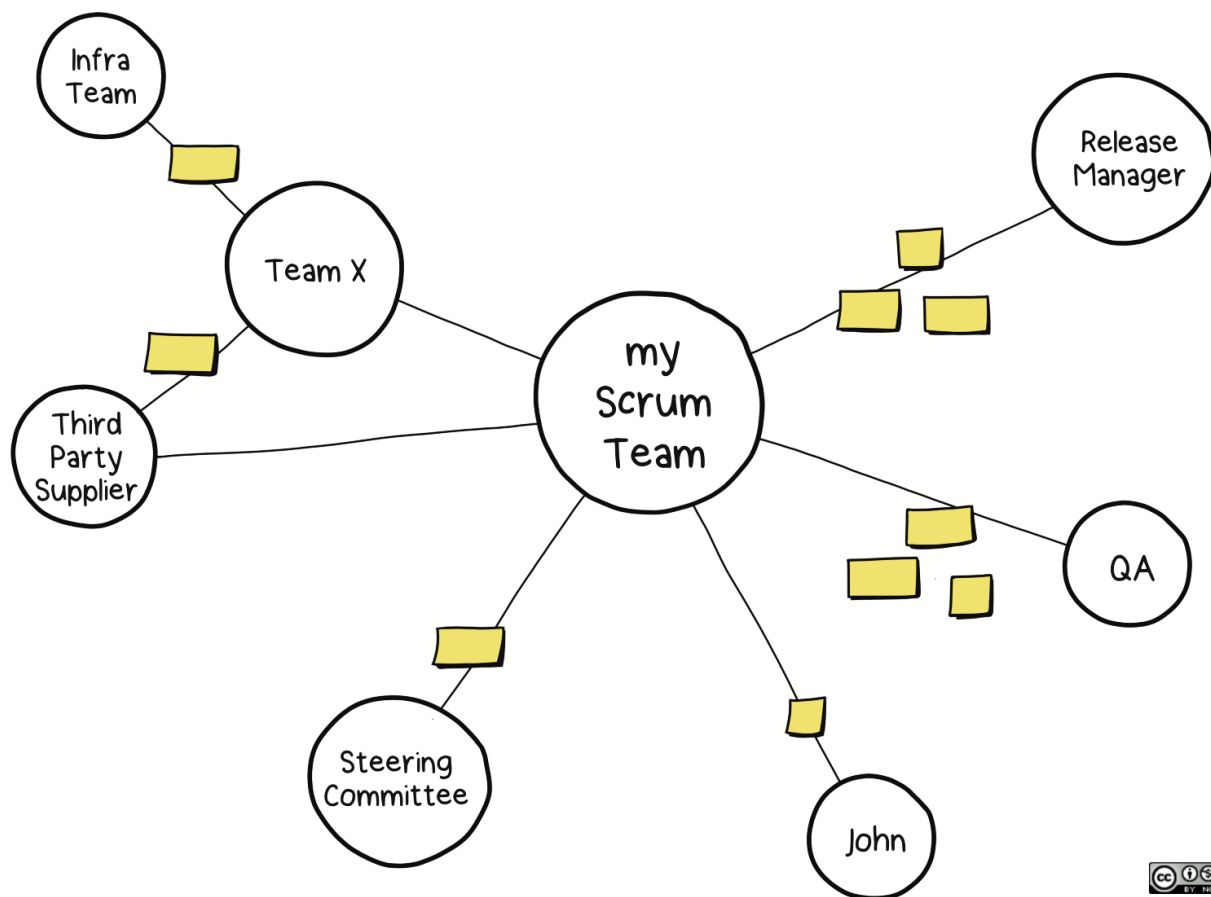


4. Map Dependencies To Find Bottlenecks

It is hard for a Scrum team to ship fast when it has to wait on other departments, teams, or suppliers to do something they depend on. For example, when deployments are performed by an external team that is swamped with other work. Or when another department has to perform specialized testing before approval is given.

Whatever their dependencies, they are generally outside of the control of a team. That makes the delays unpredictable. Even when a Scrum team considers something "Done", weeks or months may pass before their work actually reaches stakeholders. This greatly impedes a team's ability to work empirically and reduce the risk associated with complex work.

This experiment is about creating transparency around dependencies and the effect they have on your team's ability to ship fast. This experiment was inspired by the Dependency Spiders in Jimmy Janlen's ["96 Visualization Examples"](#) (which contains many other useful visualizations).



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by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Scharlau & Barry Overeem
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Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



Mapping dependencies and calculating wait time are easy.

Impact On Survival



Removing or reducing dependencies is a great way to ship faster.

Steps

To implement this experiment, do the following:

1. Draw your Scrum team in the middle of a big piece of paper. Together, create a list of the teams, people, and departments you frequently need something from in order to create a Done Increment or release it. Whose approval do you need? Who needs to perform an activity in order for your team to continue? Draw the sources that you depend on around your team, like the legs of a spider.
2. Whenever your team needs something from someone outside the team, capture the request and the date it was issued on a sticky note and put it next to the source on the canvas. When the request is fulfilled, write the number of days you had to wait on the sticky. At the end of the Sprint, calculate the average wait time in days for all the requests that have been fulfilled, and move them to an archive.
3. Use the Dependency Spider and the average wait time as input for your Sprint Reviews and Sprint Retrospectives. What actions can you take to reduce the impact of dependencies on your ability to ship? How can you include and collaborate with them to remove or reduce dependencies? How can you leverage support from your Product Owner and stakeholders to change the environment of your Scrum team so that you can ship value to them faster?

Our Findings

- Dependency Spiders are a wonderful tool to visualize what is preventing the system from becoming more effective. You may find that the people you depend on also have dependencies of their own. Although it can be simpler to limit your analysis to the dependencies of your team, you will get a more complete picture of the overall dependencies by inviting other teams, people, and departments to participate.

An Experience From The Field

"We used Dependency Spiders to understand a huge dependency that was impeding our ability to ship a large infrastructure product. Releasing new Increments was outsourced to a service provider. Because they used a different schedule and worked for many other customers, our requests would end up somewhere down a lengthy backlog. Not only did we have to wait an unpredictable number of weeks for something to happen, when they finally got around to it they'd bombard us with questions and issues that disrupted our focus from the current Sprint.

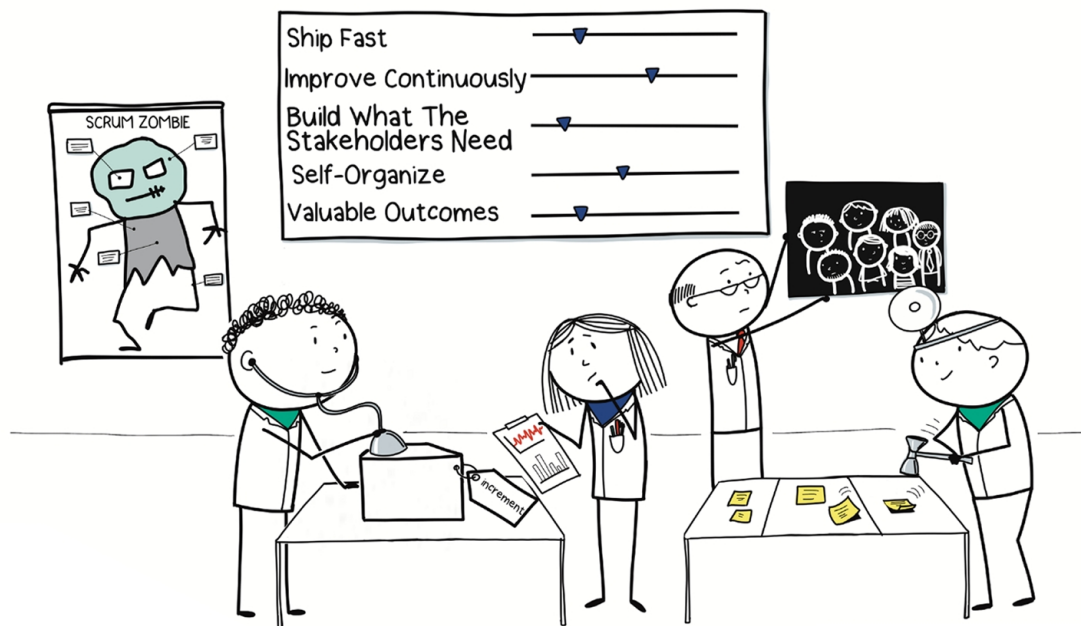
After creating awareness around the wait time, and the impact it was having on our focus and ability to get feedback from stakeholders, the Product Owner worked with management and the service provider to assign a part-time release engineer to each of the five Scrum teams. Although there was no requirement to be physically present, we noticed that most of the release engineers made an effort to be with the teams in person."



5. Use Compliment Postcards To Create Safety

Continuous improvement is the lifeblood of Scrum teams. But Scrum teams that lack psychological safety find it hard to learn and improve. Both require trying new things and talking openly about mistakes.

One way to create a safe environment is to help teams recognize and appreciate helpful contributions as they happen. This doesn't always come naturally, and this experiment is designed to help teams learn how to do this. This experiment was inspired by a Scrum Master we worked with – Barry Meijer – and has similarities with Management 3.0's excellent Kudo Cards.



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Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



Filling in a compliment card isn't hard if you set the example.

Impact On Survival



Being more appreciative of what people contribute is a simple – but very important – way to get out of Zombie Scrum.

Steps

To implement this experiment, do the following:

1. Get a set of empty postcards. We always like to bring cards with motivational texts, odd pictures, and other nice encouragements. You can also switch for the aforementioned Kudo Cards.
2. At the end of a Scrum event, give people an opportunity to fill in a compliment postcard for someone else who was present. This is optional. Encourage people to look for moments when someone else contributed to the team's ability to learn and grow. For example, when someone shared an intriguing observation, raised a thought-provoking question, or did something out of their comfort zone. The Sprint Retrospective, Sprint Planning, and the Sprint Review are the most natural opportunities.
3. Give everyone the opportunity to give the postcard to the person they wrote it for. Afterward, collect the postcards somewhere in the team room.
4. Leave a stack of compliment cards in the team room for use when an opportunity presents itself. Whenever someone fills in a postcard, they give it to the person it is for. Afterward, add the postcard to the existing set in the team room.

Our Findings

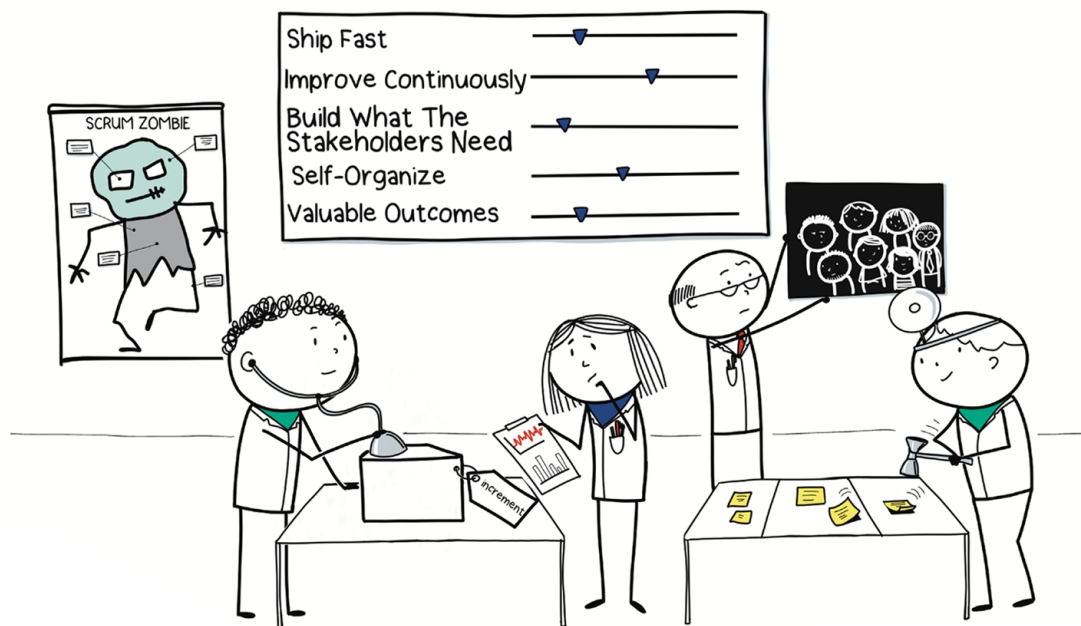
- Only honest compliments matter. Instead of making this an obligatory activity for the whole team to sit through, let people write compliment cards during breaks or after the event. This reduces the peer pressure to write cards "because everyone else is doing it".
- Model the desired behavior as the initiator of this experiment. Make an effort to appreciate contributions that may not seem helpful at first glance, but do help the team learn and grow. For example: taking a personal risk by gently challenging a decision that the majority of a team agrees with or admitting to a mistake.
- When you work with virtual teams, you can replace physical compliment postcards with virtual ones. For example, you can create a #complimentcard channel in Slack or share a simple template that people can fill in.



6. Reiterate The Purpose Of The Product At The Start Of Each Scrum Event

Scrum makes so much more sense for Scrum teams when they understand the purpose of their product. Unfortunately, Scrum teams that operate in environments with Zombie Scrum often don't know why their product matters, what their stakeholders need, or what is valuable to them. They end up doing whatever ends up on their Product Backlog without having a sense of it all ties together. Or worse, they don't know the purpose of their product. Or there isn't even a product.

This experiment describes one tiny technique that can create big shifts in how teams experience the Scrum events and the decisions they make during them.



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Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



Provided you have a product purpose, this is an easy one to do.

Impact On Survival



A great start for important conversations.

Steps

To implement this experiment, do the following:

1. Prepare visual aids to communicate the product purpose, like a product vision board or a purpose printed on a banner. You can easily bring these with you to the various Scrum events. If you don't have a purpose statement at all, refer to "Our Findings" below for suggestions.
2. Begin each Scrum event by reiterating the purpose of the product you're working on. It doesn't have to be literally the first thing you say, but make sure to mention it somewhere in the introduction. It's even better when you tie it to the purpose of the various Scrum events.
3. For the Sprint Review: "We are developing this product to [purpose]. Let's use this Sprint Review to gather feedback on how the results from this Sprint have helped us make progress on that";
4. For the Sprint Planning: "We are developing this product to [purpose]. Let's use this Sprint Planning to decide what we're going to do this Sprint and how we will be working together to work towards that";
5. For the Sprint Retrospective: "We are developing this product to [purpose]. Let's use this Sprint Retrospective to figure out how we can collaborate more effectively to work towards that";
6. For the Daily Scrum: "We are developing this product to [purpose]. How can we collaborate most effectively in the next 24 hours to work towards that purpose?". You don't have to mention this every time;

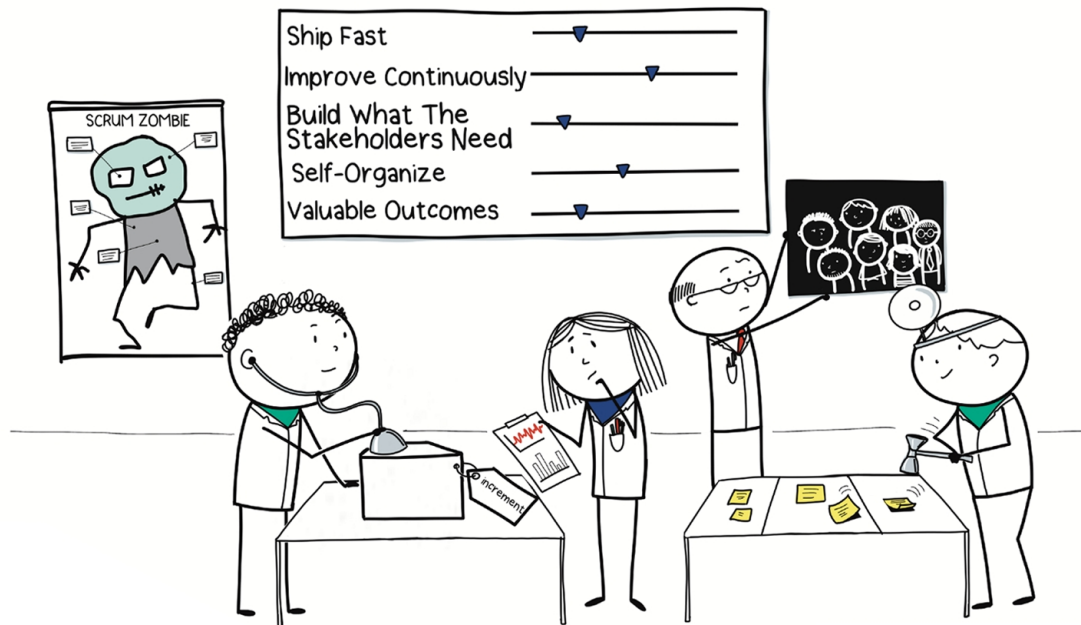
Our Findings

- There is a risk of this becoming a mantra that is only mentioned, but not acted on in what happens next. Especially when the product's purpose is abstract and vague. A good way to prevent this is to find different ways or metaphors to express the purpose, let someone else do it each time, or re-invent the product purpose periodically. Keep it fresh.
- If you don't have a purpose statement for your product, this is an excellent opportunity to create the first version. The Liberating Structure "Nine Whys" can be a huge help here. Don't worry about finding the perfect sentence to complete "This product exists in order to"; it's better to have an incomplete, rough sense of why your product matters than no sense at all.



7. Start A Book Club To Learn Together

It takes creativity and out-of-the-box thinking to solve the many hard challenges we face when trying to work empirically. Thankfully, books, blog posts, and podcasts are great sources for new ideas and inspiration. This experiment is all about drawing in new ideas from new sources to spur innovation.



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Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



Starting this initiative is easy. Turning it into a recurring event requires some perseverance.

Impact On Survival



Creating a culture where people actively seek out new ideas and possibilities is a major ingredient in overcoming Zombie Scrum.

Steps

To implement this experiment, do the following:

1. Pick a book, a blog post, or a podcast to start with. See some recommendations below. We offer some suggestions below.
2. Invite people in a way that emphasizes that participation is optional. Don't make people feel bad when they don't join. It works better to have one or two intrinsically motivated members than a whole group of people who don't really want to be there.
3. Pick a date for the first gathering **60 min**. Schedule a time during work hours; learning also works. Distribute copies of the book, the blog post, or the podcast. Ask people to prepare by reading the blog post, listening to the podcast, or reading (part of) the book.
4. Open the first gathering by clarifying the purpose; to gather useful insights and novel ideas from reading books, blog posts, and listening to podcasts.
5. First individually, ask people to make a list of their personal takeaways. Ask: "What was surprising, exciting, or insightful to you?". Invite people to share and build on their insights, first in pairs **2 min** than with another pair **4 min**. Collect big takeaways from the whole group **10 min**.
6. First individually, ask people to consider how this might benefit them or their team. Ask: "What applications or uses do you see that might benefit you or our team? ". Invite people to share and build on their insights, first in pairs **2 min** than with another pair **4 min**. Collect applications with potential from the whole group **10 min**.
7. Use "[15% Solutions](#)" to translate the most promising application(s) into tangible, individual actions.
8. Schedule a new gathering.



Our Findings

- Make the decision of what to read a joint decision of the group.
- Resist the temptation to cancel or postpone this gathering in favor of getting more work done. Building a learning culture takes time and persistence.

More Resources

- The podcast "[Agile for Humans](#)" by Ryan Ripley.
- The book "[The Phoenix Project](#)" by Gene Kim, Kevin Behr, and George Spafford.
- With developers, read "[Clean Code](#)" by Robert C. Martin. Or "[The Pragmatic Programmer](#)" by Andrew Hunt.
- The podcast "[The Scrum Master Toolbox](#)" by Vasco Duarte.
- Blog posts by people like [Gunther Verheyen](#), [John Cutler](#), [Geoff Watts](#), [Roman Pichler](#) or [Stephanie Ockerman](#).
- Novel ideas often come from unexpected sources. Don't be afraid to venture beyond the domain of product development by exploring books about economics, organizational design, autobiographies, and psychology. For example, books like [Images of Organization](#), [Social Physics](#), [Black Swan](#), and [Bullshit Jobs](#) are not directly about software- or product development, but there are many meaningful insights to distill from them.
- We feel self-conscious about plugging our own content, but we hope [our podcast](#) (50+ episodes) and [blog](#) (250+ articles) also offer value.
- This [whitepaper about the purpose of the Scrum Framework](#) is a good way to refresh what it is all about.

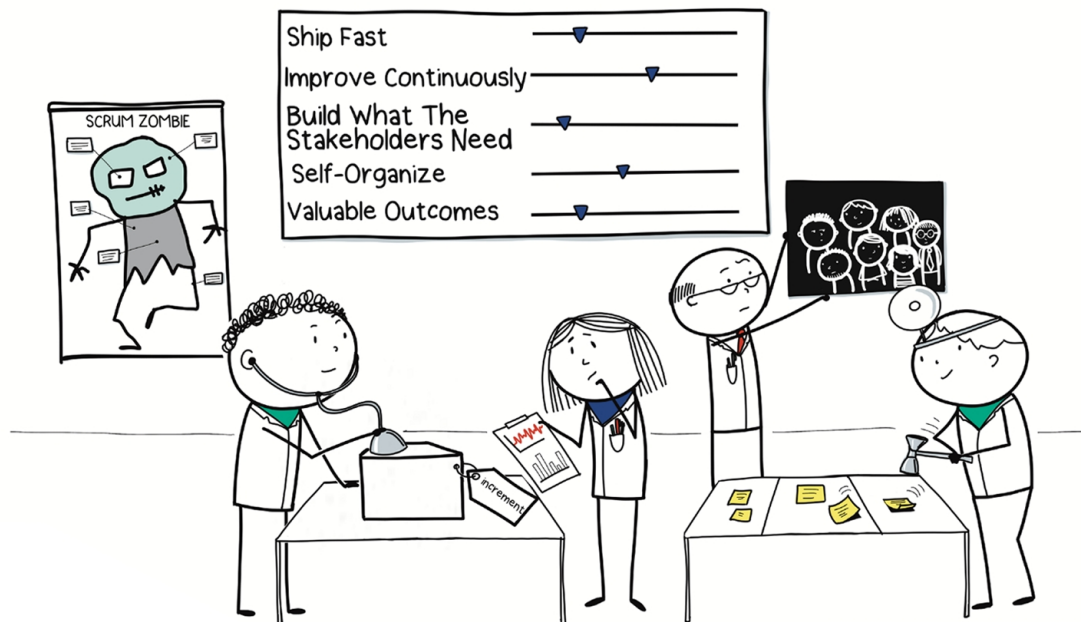


8. Use Critical Incident Reviews To Build Antifragility

Mistakes are inevitable in complex work. Instead of trying to avoid them, you can use them to grow stronger. Unfortunately, many Scrum teams don't know how to effectively learn from mistakes.

Yet, improving *from* mistakes is at the core of "Antifragility". Instead of trying to resist variation and shocks, antifragile systems grow stronger when they are pressured. For example, engineering teams at Netflix created a tool called "Chaos Monkey" to randomly terminate services in their infrastructure. Every time a terminated service ends up causing disruptions to end-users, engineering teams redesign the architecture to reduce the impact. Over time, responding to random shocks helps Netflix to make its infrastructure stronger. Space Exploration Technologies (SpaceX) has a launch cadence that is purposefully higher than other launch providers. Every time a launch fails, their self-managed teams update technology, protocols, and processes to avoid similar failures in the future.

This experiment uses the Liberating Structure "[What, So What, Now What](#)" to help teams reflect on failure and use it to identify what can be done to make the system (of their team & organization) stronger against similar and other failures.



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



Critical Incident Reviews benefit from clear facilitation and asking powerful questions to dig deeper.

Impact On Survival



The skill to analyze and learn from mistakes is vital for self-organization and continuous improvement.

Steps

To implement this experiment, do the following:

1. Run this experiment as soon as possible after your Scrum team experiences a mistake. This can be a huge, highly impactful mistake or a smaller one. The more serious the mistake, the more time you want to take to learn from it. Include whoever was involved in, or affected by, this mistake.
2. First, give people time to detach themselves from the emotions surrounding the mistake. In random pairs, ask people to share their experience of the mistake and its consequences **2 min**. Repeat three more times in new pairs. Then ask the whole group to share two or three patterns they noticed **5 min**.
3. Set the stage of the Critical Incident Review. The purpose is to learn from a mistake and to prevent similar ones in the future. Emphasize that they are not to assign blame, even when the mistake is attributable to a single person or subgroup because those people are part of a larger group that could've helped prevent the mistake.
4. In small groups, ask everyone to retell the story of the mistake. Ask "Working backward from the moment you discovered the mistake, create a timeline of what happened. What were the actions? Who were the actors? How did information flow? Who was missing?". Encourage people to channel their inner detective and leave opinions, interpretations, and conclusions aside for now. Give everyone time to get their own thinking started **2 min**, then work together in their small groups to create the timeline **15 min**. With the whole group, share the timelines and notice similarities and differences **10 min**.
5. Now that the group has a better sense of what actually happened, ask "What is important about this? What does this mean about our work as a team? What conclusions can we draw?". First individually and in silence **2 min**, then invite people to share their ideas in their small groups **5 min**. Capture the most important insights with the whole group **10 min**.
6. Help the group turn their discoveries from the previous round into improvements. Ask "Now what? How can we reduce the blast radius of similar mistakes in the future or avoid them altogether?". First individually and in silence **2 min**, then invite people to share their ideas in their small groups **5 min**. Capture the most important ideas with the whole group **10 min**. Formulate [15% Solutions](#) for the most promising actions.

Our Findings

- For another perspective, you can use different colors for everyone in your team. This allows you to identify who is most often in need of permission.
- If you want to focus on the amount of organizational bureaucracy, don't add permission tokens for requests from direct stakeholders like customers, users, or people who otherwise invest significant money or time in your product.

An Experience From The Field

"A few years ago, most of our web-based infrastructure collapsed all of a sudden. Everyone scrambled to figure out what happened while at the same answering phone calls and emails from concerned customers. It turned out that a few SSL-certificates had expired at the same time, some of which were used by web-services that most of our web-applications relied on. Although finding and fixing the issue took 25 minutes, it took much longer for us to appease angry customers.

During a 'Critical Incident Review' with the entire team, we discovered that one member of our team had been notified of the upcoming expiration a week before, but ignored the email because he assumed it had already been taken care of. Since we relied on many different SSL-certificates, we often received notifications about expiration – some important, some not. To strengthen our system against similar failures in the future, we developed three solutions.



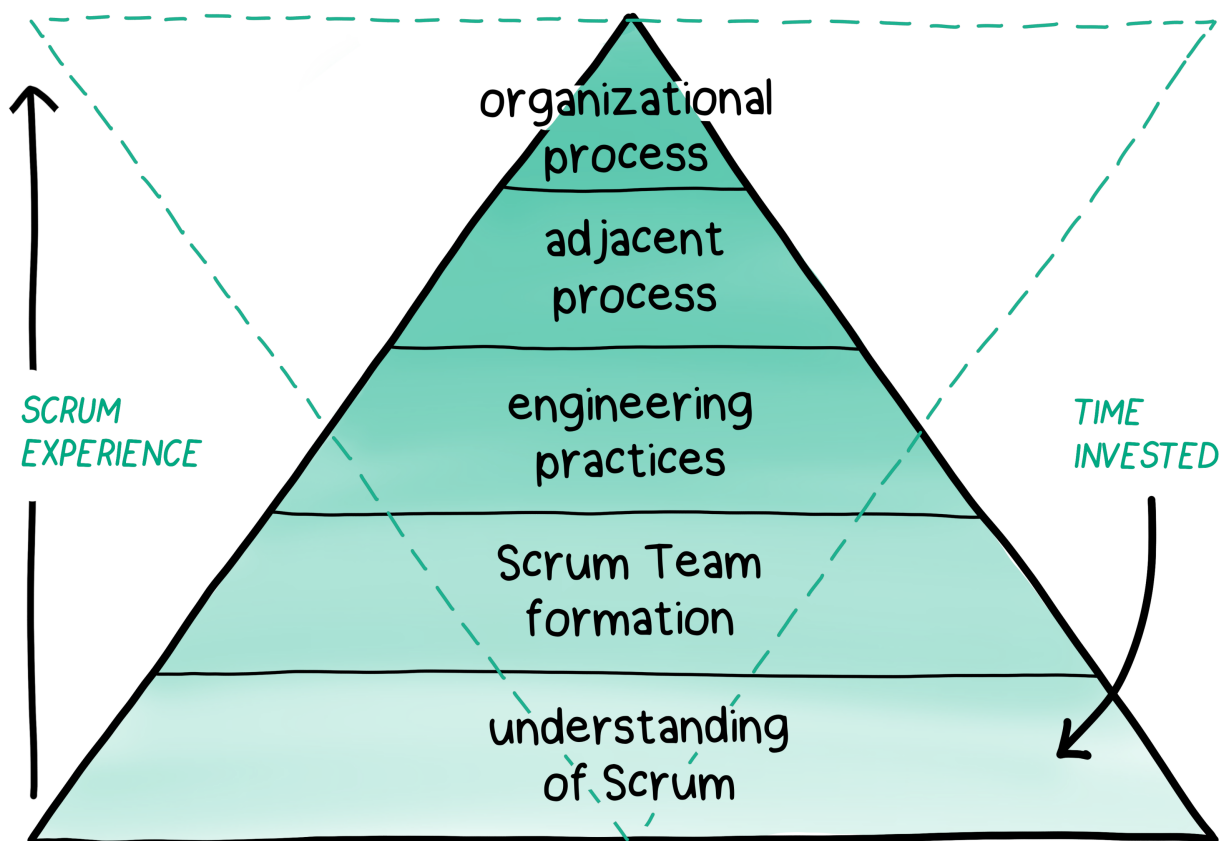
The first was the installation of a simple monitoring tool on a screen in the team room that turned red when an SSL-certificate was within days of expiration. The second was that we switched to auto-renewed SSL-certificates wherever possible, starting with the most critical services- a technology that wasn't available before. Finally, we made the responsibility to update SSL certificates (and monitor them) a responsibility of the entire team - not just one person. Since that review, we haven't had other issues with expiring SSL-certificates. In fact, we found the monitoring tool so helpful that we expanded it with checks for response-time, certain security issues, and 'chatty HTTP headers'."



9. Share An Impediment Newsletter Throughout The Organization

The impediments that make it hard for Scrum teams to work empirically often involve people across the organization. When you help them understand the impediments and the problems they cause, you create awareness about what can be improved. This, in turn, opens the door to double-loop learning and to systemic improvements.

We designed this simple experiment to help you create awareness about the problems that your team is running into. After all, if nobody else knows, nothing will ever change.



AS SCRUM TEAMS BECOME MORE EXPERIENCED
WITH SCRUM, THE PYRAMID FLIPS

model by dominik maximini



Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



This experiment calls for nothing but courage and a dash of tact.

Impact On Survival



Although painful, this is a great way to create urgency around the biggest problems.

Steps

To try this experiment, do the following:

1. With your Scrum team, ask everyone to silently write down impediments they see that are making it hard for them to build what stakeholders need and/or ship fast(er). What skills are missing? Where is protocol getting in the way? Which people do they need, but don't have access to? After a few minutes, invite people to pair up to share and build on their individual ideas. Together, share all impediments and pick the three to five impediments that are most impactful (e.g. with dot-voting).
2. For the biggest impediments, ask "What is lost because of this? What do we and our stakeholders gain when this impediment would be removed?". Capture the consequences of the various impediments.
3. For the biggest impediments, ask "Where do we need help? What would help look like?". Collect the requests for help for the various impediments.
4. Compile the biggest impediments, including their consequences and requests for help, in a format that you can easily distribute to everyone who has a stake in your work. It could be a mailing, a paper newsletter, a blog post on your intranet, or a poster that you put in a heavy-traffic corridor. Include the purpose of your team and how to contact you. You can also include the accomplishments of your team, of course.

Our Findings

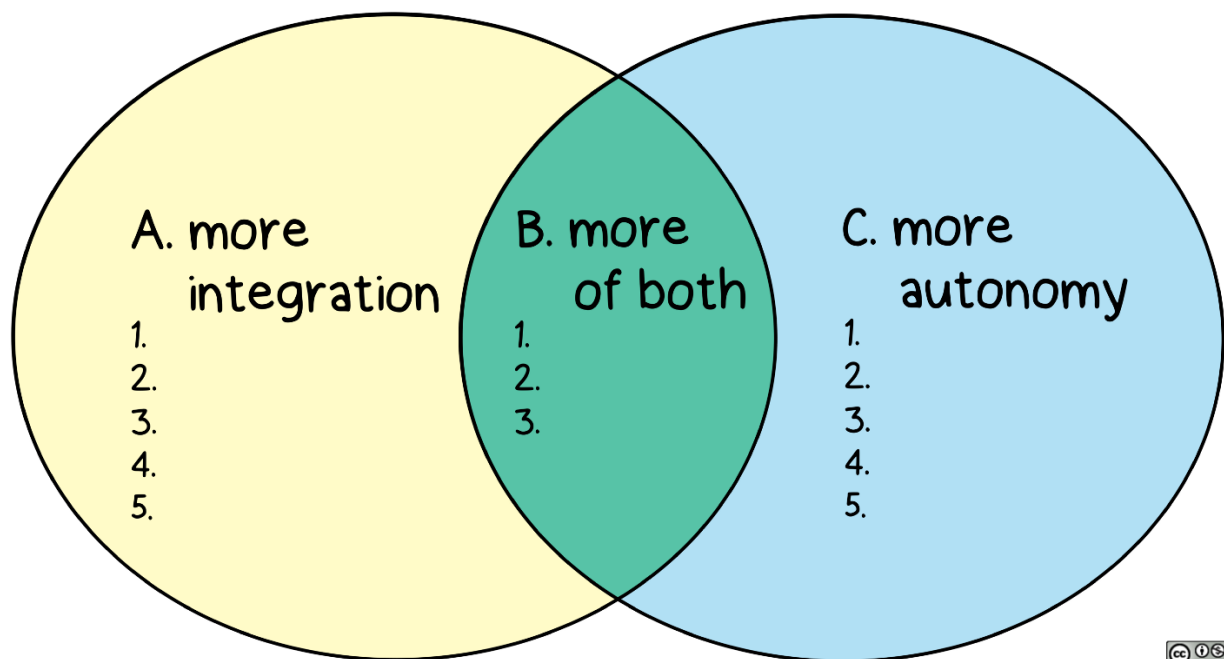
- Make sure to include (higher) management and consider informing them upfront. Also, they will probably appreciate a shorter, more concise version.
- Transparency can be painful. Be honest but tactful in your messaging, and don't blame others or be negative. State what is happening and make clear requests for help.
- If you are planning to do this frequently, make sure to include the accomplishments of your team as well. What is going well? What has changed since the previous newsletter? And most importantly; from whom did you receive (unexpected) help?



10. Find Actions That Boost Both Integration And Autonomy

Organizations with self-managing Scrum teams face the difficult challenge of balancing their autonomy while keeping their work integrated with the rest of the organization. Because both of these aspects are equally desirable, and we can't simply make an either-or decision, we are faced with what is called a "wicked question".

Instead of letting the pendulum swing entirely to one side, this experiment is about finding ways of supporting both sides. With this approach, you help groups move from "either-or" to "yes-and" thinking. This experiment and its corresponding worksheet are based on the Liberating Structure [Integrated~Autonomy](#).



model by Henri Lipmanowicz & Keith McCandless


Created by Thea Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijns, Johannes Scharlau & Barry Overbeem
zombiescrum.org

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



This experiment greatly benefits from tight facilitation and asking powerful questions to help the group move out of deadlocks.

Impact On Survival



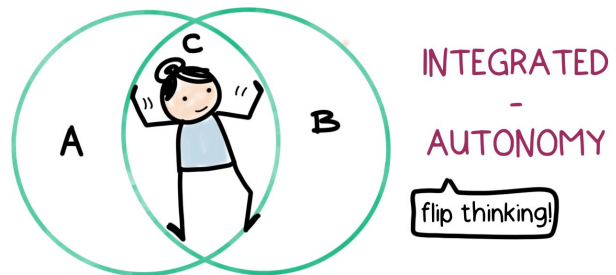
As people start seeing that autonomy and integration are not opposed, more of both will be possible.



Steps

To try this experiment, do the following:

1. Invite people who have a stake in either increasing the autonomy of Scrum teams or keeping them integrated with work done elsewhere. This includes the Scrum teams themselves, departments they depend on (and vice versa), and management.
2. Begin by helping people make tensions between autonomy and integration tangible. Ask "For the Scrum teams, where in their work is there tension between the desire for autonomy and the desire for integration?" Start with a minute of silent thinking **1 min**, then invite people to share their ideas in pairs **2 min**. Capture salient examples from the whole group **5 min**. For example, there can be tension between the autonomy that Scrum teams have over their Sprint Backlog and the need to be able to pick up urgent issues from people outside the team that emerge during a Sprint. There can be tension between the autonomy of a Product Owner to order the Product Backlog and keeping that ordering aligned with corporate strategy. Or between allowing Scrum teams to pick their own tools and having mandated tools that are safe for corporate environments.
3. The next step is to explore actions that promote integration. For this step, the participants work with the Integrated~Autonomy worksheet. It shows three columns with space for writing down ideas that lead to either more integration (A), more autonomy (C), or both (B). The group will focus on column A first. Ask "What actions boost integration of the Scrum teams' activities with what is happening elsewhere?" Start with a minute of silent thinking **1 min**, then invite people to share their ideas in groups of four **5 min**. Capture the most salient actions from the small groups on the left side of the worksheet **10 min**.
4. As a follow-up, explore actions that promote autonomy. Ask "What actions boost the autonomy of Scrum teams?" Capture them in the right column of the worksheet. Start with a minute of silent thinking **1 min**, then invite people to share their ideas in groups of four **5 min**. Capture the most salient actions from the small groups on the right side of the worksheet **10 min**.
5. Now that you have actions that each address one side of the wicked question, help the group move into yes-and thinking. Ask "Which actions boost both integration and autonomy?" Capture them on the worksheet in the middle. Start with a minute of silent thinking **1 min**, then invite people to share their ideas in groups of four **5 min**. Capture the most salient actions from the small groups on the middle of the worksheet **10 min**.
6. Now that people have experience identifying actions that serve both sides, investigate earlier actions to see if they can be shifted to the middle. Ask "Which actions on the left or the right of the worksheet can be creatively modified to boost both integration and autonomy?" Start with a minute of silent thinking **1 min**, then invite people to share their ideas in groups of four **5 min**. Capture the most salient actions from the small groups on the middle of the worksheet **10 min**.
7. Order actions by their ability to promote both integration and autonomy and identify [15% Solutions](#) for the most impactful ones.



Our Findings

- Coming up with specific and tangible actions can be difficult. Keep asking "How would you do that for us?" or "What would that look like here?" in order to move groups beyond abstract ideas and platitudes (such as "more communication").
- If you have a large group, you can make each group of four responsible for one of the actions you identified during step 2. Let them fill in the entire worksheet in their small group from the perspective of that action.
- You can replace the sides—integration and autonomy—with other wicked challenges. For example, there is also tension between responding to change as quickly as possible and preventing huge mistakes. Or the tension between standardization on the one hand and customization on the other. Work with whatever wicked challenge makes the most sense!



More Resources & Material For The Experiments



- Whitepaper: [Scrum: A Framework to Reduce Risk And Deliver Value Sooner](#)
- Whitepaper: [The 8 Stances of a Scrum Master](#) illustrates well why Scrum Masters are responsible for removing certain impediments.
- Research: [How Do Scrum Masters Deal With Problems Outside Of Their Team's Control?](#). Together with [Age of Product](#), we asked Scrum Masters how they overcame impediments (including dependencies).
- Blog post: [What Makes Scrum Teams Effective?](#)
- Blog post: [Conflict Styles: What Sciences Says](#)
- Blog post: [How Swarming Helps Agile Teams Deliver](#)
- Blog post: [Navigating Conflict, a Lifetime of Work](#)
- Blog post: [Experiments, Practices, and Strategies for being a Remote Scrum Master](#)
- Blog post: [10 Success Factors To Resolve Zombie Scrum](#)
- Blog post: [Start Your Own Zombie Scrum Learning Journey](#)
- Blog post: [What it means to be a cross-functional team, and what it doesn't](#)
- Tool: [The Zombie Scrum First Aid Kit](#) is a great way to periodically create transparency.
- Tool: Use the [Scrum Team Starter kit](#) to unmask the tough impediments that your team faces, you can start overcoming them together.
- Tool: [Kudo Cards](#), created by Management 3.0, are also a nice way to show appreciation.
- Podcast: [Why Liberating Structures Are Instruments For Self-Organization](#)
- Podcast: [Scrum Mythbusters: The Scrum Master Must Resolve Every Problem](#)

Looking For More?



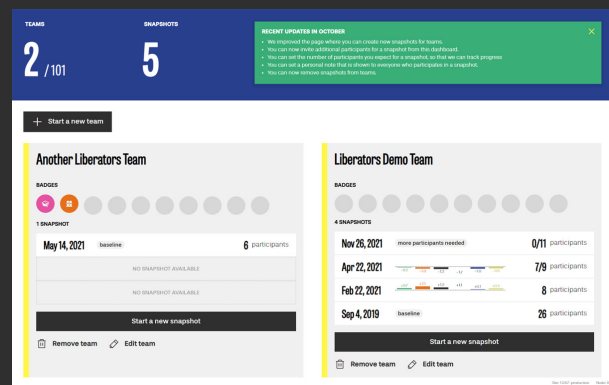
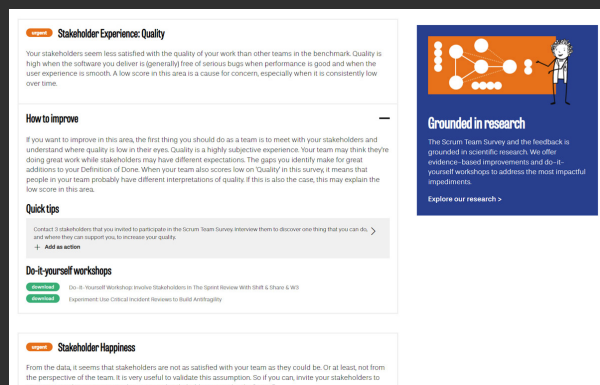
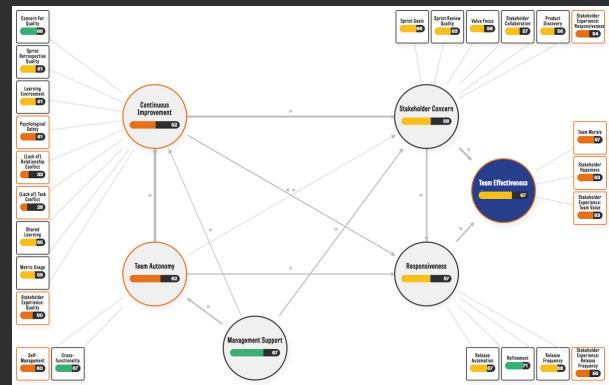
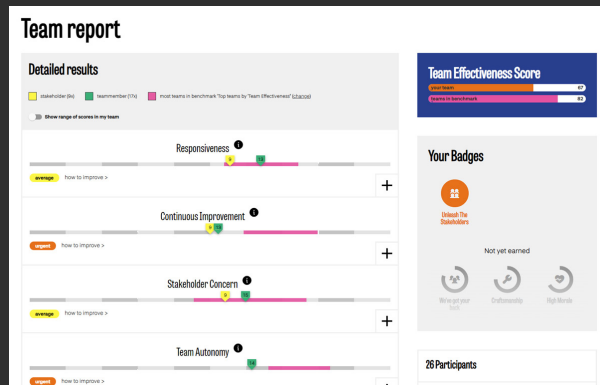
If you liked these experiments, you're bound to like the 36 other experiments we published in our book, "The Zombie Scrum Survival Guide". You can order it online at <https://zombiescrum.org>.

Another great way to expand your toolbox is to develop more of these recipes in your organization, with your community of Scrum Masters, your coaching chapter, or even on your own. If you follow our template, you're bound to end up with practical and down-to-earth experiments that can be used by pretty much anyone. If you do develop your own, we'd love to hear about them too. We can also offer feedback and (if you want) include your experiments in our library. Contact us at info@zombiescrum.org.



Make Your Scrum Team More Effective

Want to make your Scrum team more effective? We created the Scrum Team Survey to help. Invite members and stakeholders to a detailed questionnaire and diagnose the results together. You receive tons of actionable feedback based on your results, including dozens of quick tips and useful do-it-yourself workshops. You can use the Scrum Team Survey for free with your team. No account or e-mail address is required. You can also subscribe for more advanced features.



	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

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